

November 2013

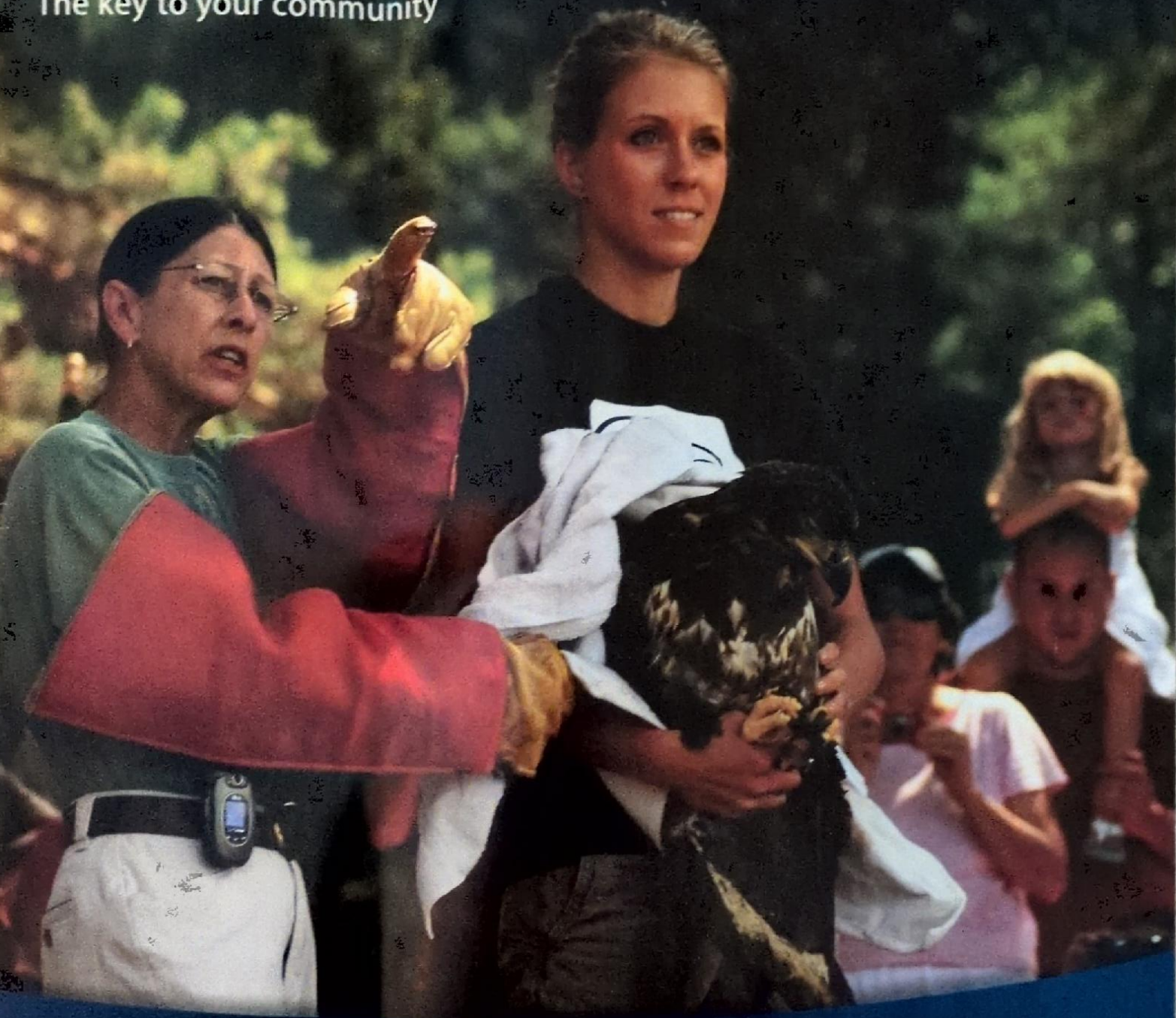
Trash or Treasure?
AMAZING RESULTS

Growing a School Garden
WASHAM KIDS DIG IT

Let Your Vote Be Heard
CORNELIUS BONDS

Cornelius Life

The key to your community



Rescuing Raptors

Our Small Raptor Center Gains a Worldwide Reputation

Cornelius Life

The key to your community

Inside

- 14** Carolina Raptor Center Treats More Than 1,000 Birds a Year
- 18** More Trash-or-Treasure Days?
- 21** Police: Play It Safe on Halloween
- 7** Gardens Grow at Washam Elem
- 30** Lake Norman Shows Its Talent

Departments

5 From the Editor

What's special this month — in the magazine, and the area.

7 Around Town

People, places, problems, good causes and occasions.

23 Gotta Go!

Best bets for upcoming concerts, shows and events.

25 Snapshots

Community residents share their photos with readers.

27 Calendar

Your guide to music, theater, kid stuff and lots more.

30 And Another Thing ...

A fond farewell from this month's issue of the magazine.

On the Cover

Master volunteer Anne Steinert, left, and Carolina Raptor Center staffer Carly Smith ready American bald eagle Independence for release on July 4, 2011. Above right, great horned owl "Betbait" (third from left) fosters more than 20 orphaned chicks a year at the center.

Cover photo by Michele Miller Houck, Carolina Raptor Center



Meet Jessica Harvey: photographer, wife, mom, former Marine and our contributor.

I am a local photographer. My passion for photography began while I was stationed in Japan as a U.S. Marine. I follow my daughter and husband around constantly. I contribute my expertise to Cornelius Life so I can share photos of Cornelius neighbors having fun together.

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14

Photo by Bill Hager



7

Photo courtesy of Washam Elementary School



18

Photo courtesy of Yolanda Mason



30

Photo by Jessica Harvey, Oh Shoot! Photograph



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Raptor Hospital in the Wood

Carolina Raptor Center's Jim Arthur Medical Center saw over 1,000 patients in 2012.

by Michele Miller Houk and Emily Zhu
Community contributors

You may not know this but tucked away in the woods of northern Mecklenburg County is a medical facility for birds, a Raptor Medical Center, that admits more than 1,000 large birds of prey every year. Any research that you do on the more than 60 facilities in North America that treat raptors tells you that Carolina Raptor Center may be the largest raptor treatment facility in the United States – and possibly the world.

The facility's modest medical director, Dr. Dave Scott, shies away from superlatives like "biggest" or "busiest," but he loves his job as the staff veterinarian and avian surgeon at the Huntersville location inside Latta Plantation Nature Preserve. The staff of three full-time and two part time members works 12 hours a day, 7 days a week and 365 days a year to keep the facility growing and accepting new patients. More than 300 volunteers assist in surgery, perform physical therapy, feed birds, administer medicine, transport injured birds and do whatever is necessary to get their avian patients back into the wild.

Their efforts to fix and release birds are as successful as any other wildlife center in the country. The hospital's patients are released back into the wild almost 70 percent of the time – if they live through the first 24 hours, the most critical time.

2012 was a record year, with 1,014 birds admitted to the medical center: 233 red-shouldered hawks, 196 barred owls, 165 red-tailed hawks, 97 great horned owls, 97 cooper's hawks, 51 eastern screech owls, 41 black vultures, 30 broad winged hawks, 23 turkey vultures, 20 barn owls, 16 osprey, 11 sharp shinned hawks, 11 American kestrels, nine bald eagles and nine other birds.

Injuries range from broken bones to lead poisoning and are primarily caused by interaction with humans. "We feel a responsibility to take care of these birds, especially because most of the reasons that they are in this condition are directly caused by humans," Scott says. "We are thrilled that so many of them – almost 70 percent – are successfully returned to the wild."

The primary cause of injury for birds brought into the medical center is "hit by car." This occurs when litter attracts rodents and other small mammals to the side of the road. The raptor – following its instinct—focuses completely on this available prey and often never sees the car. So raptor center staff frequently tell visitors and friends not to throw litter of any kind – even biodegradable litter – out their car windows. This would go a long way to prevent many of the injuries to birds rehabilitated at Carolina Raptor Center. One other cause worth

mentioning is "gunshot wounds." Even though shooting migratory birds is illegal, Carolina Raptor Center saw 40 gunshot wounds in 2012.

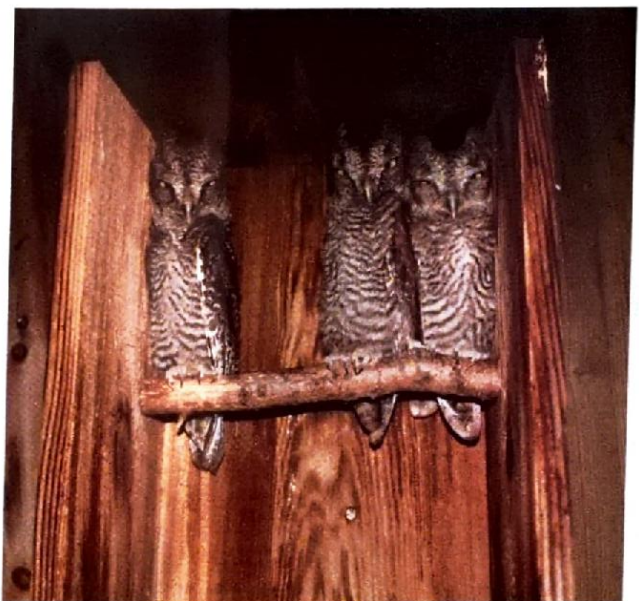
The day-to-day workings

Daily work begins about 7 a.m., when staff and volunteers arrive to feed the birds and administer medicine. Reports from RaptorMed, the raptor center's proprietary medical record developed here by Scott, guide daily treatments, feeding and medicine doses. Typical mornings find Scott and his staff performing physical therapy, wrapping and rewrapping bandages, exercising birds and checking on new admissions.

RAPTOR MED ENTRY: Thursday, AUG.15, 10:45 a.m.

An interesting case today with our resident black vulture, Bonsai. He has had some swelling in his left eye, and we brought him in to check it out. Staffers Carly Smith and Mathias Engelmann went out to his enclosure and caught him – not an easy task for a fully flighted vulture who is not sure about the medical staff. Brought him into X-ray to see if Dr. Scott could inject luminescent dye into his tear duct so that the structures could be checked via X-ray. After an unsuccessful attempt at injecting the thick dye, the obstruction was flushed out and saved for analysis later. After recovering from the effects of the anesthesia, Bonsai was returned to his enclosure.

Calls come in throughout the day for assistance with injured birds. The far flung corps of transport volunteers are called upon to go and pick up a bird from the many counties surrounding Carolina Raptor Center. Area veterinarians and animal-



Orphaned young eastern screech owls huddle together for protection. During orphan season (February through August), the center gets as many as 20 new birds a day.

Photo courtesy of Bill Hager

control officers are aware of center's reputation for repairing large birds of prey and regularly refer these animals to the medical center. Birds have "walked" into the medical center in the hands (not recommended) of private citizens, in boxes, in the grills of cars, wrapped in towels and still in fallen nests. Finders have the opportunity to participate in the release of the bird when it is available for release. Members of the general public can release birds in appropriate habitats for a suggested donation of \$150 to cover the costs of rehabilitating the bird.

RAPTOR MED ENTRY: Thursday, Aug. 8, 2:14 p.m.

Canadian volunteer Linda Boyle took patient 17092 to Rural Hill for release. Her notes from the release: "She was a large red-tailed hawk, so I guess we'll say 'she.' We drove about 5-6 miles away from Carolina Raptor Center to a large field - the perfect habitat for a red-tailed hawk. She was moving around in the box, so I waited until she settled down and then gently tipped the box and opened it up. There was a moment when she just looked out, and then she burst forth from the box - that is exactly how I would describe it. ... I think even when I return to Canada, I will believe that she has followed me home."

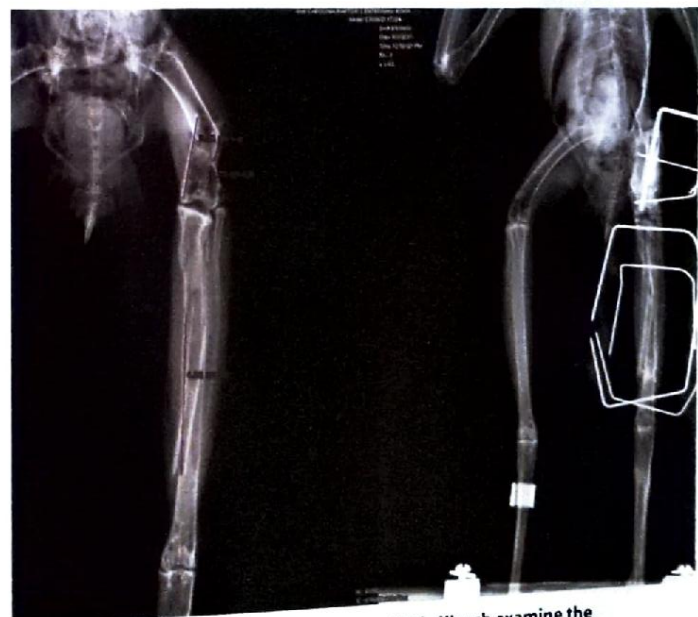
During orphan season (February through August), as many as 20 new birds are brought into the center daily from around the region. Orphan season coincides with the hatching seasons of the wide variety of species native to the Carolinas, beginning with bald eagles in February through the red-tailed hawks and vultures in the later months. Birds that fall from nests, if they cannot be re-nested successfully or if the parents are absent, are brought to Carolina Raptor Center to be raised in the orphan nursery until they are ready for release - usually a few months later. Orphans are fed with species-appropriate puppets about six times a day in the beginning by volunteers wearing camouflage to avoid imprinting the babies. Imprinting on humans can occur during the first few weeks of life and renders the birds

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Senior Rehabilitation Coordinator Mathias Englemann exercises red-tailed hawks in one of the Carolina Raptor Center's two large flight cages. Other rehab centers send birds to use these large cages.

Photo courtesy of Jeff Mittlestadt



Top, Dr. Dave Scott and volunteer nurse Katie Kinsch examine the eye of Bonsai, a resident black vulture. Middle, Junior volunteer Danielle Boal releases a rehabilitated red-shouldered hawk. Before and after X-rays for a red-shouldered hawk showing repair of a leg break. Photos: Top, Zada McCoy; middle, John Boal; and bottom, Raptor Center

Continued from previous page

unfit to survive in the wild, as the birds look to humans for food and companionship.

Seriously injured birds with broken bones are lucky to make it to Raptor Medical Center. Surgeries to repair broken bones with implants and pins go on throughout the day, sometimes two or three in a day for wings, legs and pelvises that collided with cars or windows or suffered gunshot wounds. Scott tries new surgical techniques and presents them at conferences worldwide – most recently at 2013 avian medicine conferences in Weisbaden, Germany, and Jacksonville, FL. Scott is recognized as one of the leaders in developing new surgical techniques for raptors. He has just completed a research study about a new product that stimulates growth in bone and soft tissue.

RAPTOR MED ENTRY: Friday Aug. 16, 5 p.m.

This red-shouldered hawk was admitted July 7 at 10 a.m. The finder hit the bird (no. 17204), and it got stuck in the grill of his car. Then it fell out of the grill and rolled under his tire! The X-ray confirmed the bird had a fractured left femur and tibiotarsus. We repaired both during the same procedure using seven separate implants. After surgery, the bird was doing very well. It has been moved to a flight cage, but we have not removed the implants yet. As with most birds hit by cars, there was some damage to the retina but that seems to be resolving.

Large flight cages ensure that new surgical techniques pay off in the end. Carolina Raptor Center has two large flight cages of more than 100 feet, built by volunteers under the direction of Mathias Engelmann, the senior rehabilitation coordinator who has been with the center more 30 years. Large birds come

from all over the region for rehabilitation in these massive cages that allow large birds like bald eagles to build up the flight muscles. Engelmann is considered the area's foremost raptor rehabilitator and eagle expert. He presided over the first bald eagle chicks born in captivity in the Carolinas in 2006. He was a student of founder Dick Brown, a professor of biology at the University of North Carolina at Charlotte in the late '70s and early '80s. Facilities began in the basement of the biology building at the UNC-Charlotte campus and moved to the current site at Latta Plantation Nature Preserve in 1984, when an administrator caught one of the vultures riding the elevator.

Volunteers are huge at the raptor center

Providing medical services for more than 1,000 birds a year would not work without the legions of volunteers that clean cages, feed birds, assist in surgery, administer medication and physical therapy and recover and transport injured birds. Scheduled and nurtured by Rehabilitation Coordinator Carly Smith, volunteers take on jobs that allow the medical center to be efficient and open seven days a week with limited staff.

Master level volunteer Anne Steinert was named the Wildlife Volunteer of the Year at 48th annual Governor's Achievement Awards at last year's ceremony in Raleigh. For more than 10 years, Steinert has volunteered at the raptor center, racking up an average of 800 hours a year. But it's not just her time commitment that makes her such a special volunteer. It's her total commitment to raptor conservation. If you need to get a hawk out of your industrial warehouse, she's the one to do it.

A Day in the Life

Here's a taste of a day in the life of a raptor hospital, with real entries logged at Carolina Raptor Center.

7 a.m.: Diurnal feeders arrive – Every day volunteers arrive to feed the hawks, eagles, osprey and hospital birds, usually between 40 and 200.

9:04 a.m.: Call from finder requesting transport – CRC fields daily calls from folks around the region who have found an injured or orphaned bird. Trained transport volunteers live regionally and bring it to the hospital.

9:45 a.m.: Physical therapy session under anesthesia – Birds recovering from orthopedic surgery require periodic physical therapy.

10:30 a.m.: Injured bird arrives – A full assessment is performed on a bird that enters treatment.

11:45 a.m.: Second orphan feeding –

Baby birds must be fed up to six times a day. Feeders will dress in camouflage and feed baby birds with puppets of their same species.

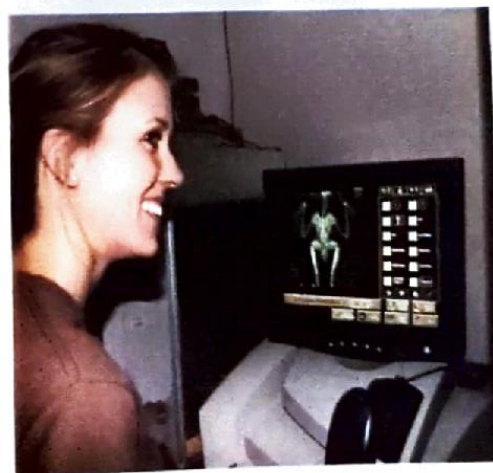
1:15 p.m.: Orthopedic repair of fracture in surgical suite.

2:30 p.m.: Mouse school in large flight cage – The last stop in the journey back to the wild is a "classroom" session on catching prey.

3 p.m.: Veterinary student dissections, autopsy – More than 20 students a year attend our RaptorVet program.

4 p.m.: Nocturnal feeders arrive – Birds active in the evening hours prefer their dinner later in the day.

5:30 pm: X-ray on new patient – Novant Health donated state-of-the-art



Rehabilitation coordinator Carly Smith transfers an X-ray into the digital RaptorMed system so that everyone can access it..
Photo by Michele Miller Houck

digital X-ray equipment.

8 pm: Great horned owl release – The culmination of all of the good work at raptor hospital is a good release. You can release one of these birds in an appropriate habitat for a suggested donation of \$150. More information is available at carolinaraptorcenter.org.